

FREE PRINTABLE

The Refrigerator Zone Map

Where everything goes and why, by temperature. Tape it inside a cabinet door until the zones become habit.

Cold air sinks: the top shelf is the warmest shelf, the bottom is the coldest, and the door swings most of all. The map follows the temperature, not the built in bins.

Eat First bin, front edge of the top shelf, at eye level. Anything within two days of its date moves here at the weekly check. It is the first place you look when planning a meal.

Top shelf — WARMEST SHELF

Leftovers in clear glass containers, dated on the lid, gone after four days. Ready to eat snacks, yogurt cups, prepped meals. Visibility is the point: if you cannot see it, it expires.

Middle shelf — STEADY COLD

Eggs in their carton, milk, cream, yogurt, hard cheese and butter wrapped tightly. Not the door, where the temperature swings fifteen degrees a day. Open box of baking soda at the back, replaced every three months.

Bottom shelf — COLDEST SHELF

Raw meat, poultry and fish only, in a leak proof container or on a rimmed plate, in the store packaging. Never above other food. Use ground meat and seafood within 2 days, poultry 3, whole cuts of beef or pork 3 to 5.

Crisper, high humidity — CLOSED VENT

Leafy greens, herbs, broccoli, asparagus. Anything that wilts when it dries out. Wash greens only if you spin and towel them dry first.

Crisper, low humidity — OPEN VENT

Apples, pears, avocados, melons, peppers. Fruit that gives off ethylene as it ripens, kept away from the greens it would wilt. Berries stay dry and unwashed until eating.

DOOR, WARMEST ZONE

Top bins — CONDIMENTS

Ketchup, mustard, soy sauce, dressings, pickles, hot sauce, jam. Enough salt, sugar, vinegar or oil to shrug off the swings.

Grouped — BY TYPE

Dressings together, hot sauces together, Asian condiments together, so three open bottles of the same thing stop happening.

Bottom bins — DRINKS

Bottled water, juice boxes, shelf stable drinks.

Not on the door

Eggs, milk, butter, fresh fruit. The bins are built for them, and it is the wrong place for all four.

BEFORE YOU RELOAD

Check the temperature

1. Appliance thermometer on the middle shelf, door closed, one hour.
2. Target 34 to 38 degrees Fahrenheit. Above 40 is the danger zone where bacteria multiply.
3. Adjust the dial, wait another hour, check again. Factory dials are often off.
4. Repeat every six months.

FIFTEEN MINUTES, THE DAY BEFORE SHOPPING

The weekly reset

1. Photo of every shelf on your phone. It doubles as the shopping list.
2. Check the Eat First bin and plan those items into the next two days.
3. Wipe any shelf with a visible spill, dry it straight away.
4. Toss anything past its date or obviously turned. No smell test; most bacteria do not smell.
5. Move anything now within two days of its date into the Eat First bin.

SUB ZONES

Clear bins, labelled

One bin each Snacks, breakfast, sandwich fixings, prepped vegetables. Pull the whole bin to see the category at once.

Clear only Acrylic or glass. Opaque bins and wicker bring back the hidden item problem.

Label them A chalkboard tag or washi tape, so everyone puts things back in the right place after shopping.

Empty bin Means that is what to buy. The list writes itself.

SMELL

Absorb, do not mask

Baking soda Open box at the back of the middle shelf, dated, replaced every three months.

Activated charcoal Small open container for stronger smells, lasts about six months.

Never Scented plug ins or gel jars near food. The perfume transfers to dairy and butter.

Weekly Wipe the door gasket and find the spill on the bottom shelf. The drip channel at the back is where musty smells start.

WHAT QUIETLY UNDOES IT

Six mistakes

1. Skipping the weekly fifteen minutes. The system drifts back within four to six weeks.
2. Eggs and milk on the door because the bins are there.
3. Washing berries or greens before storing without drying them completely.
4. Raw meat above ready to eat food. One drip is a cross contamination risk.
5. Opaque containers for sub zones.
6. Buying a third bottle of the same condiment because the door is not grouped.

Eat first this week